In The Shadows of Mystacor (S1 Ep7: She-ra 2018)

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Summary

Mystacor, abundant in customs and traditions, always had a way of preserving itself in time. It seemed like Shadow Weaver was viewing the same picture from a new perspective. Though even once she got used to looking at the pastel walls through the black tint of the shadows, a part of her vision remained blurry.

Notes

Hi everyone!!
This is our first submission for this Thank You She-Ra event to farewell the show from Netflix, and with Es we decided to post this series, which, well… was inspired by her awesome art (not posted yet cause it would be a spoiler UvU), and I couldn't resist the urge to write something with it, and she joined in, and I think her collaboration is what *really* makes this whole thing work the best possible!

Now, I hope you enjoy this first part! See you at the end notes!
~Xenakis

See the end of the work for more notes

When Shadow Weaver discovered that Adora headed for none other than the Kingdom of Mystacor, she felt the most wicked delight.

How *perfect*!

A chance to recover her ward while *also* landing a hit on those fools of the Sorcerers' Guild!?

This was the chance she had only dreamt of before.

But of course, she needed to make sure she wouldn't be interrupted, so she ordered Catra to stand watch outside her chamber.

Only then could she begin.

Aided by the power of the Black Garnet, Shadow Weaver summoned her spies, her servants, to do her bidding.

—From the farthest reaches of Etheria, I command you, *be as one*!

Immediately, a myriad of shadows converged and jumped into the basin, ready to infiltrate Mystacor… and take it *down*.

The dark sorceress was so sure it'd be extremely easy.

Over the years, her small, very secret connections with Mystacor had slowly fizzled out. Now her information on the island was gathered through public documents, news or rumours her soldiers had picked up on some expedition and dragged back into the Horde.

But it did not matter, Mystacor's picture was already built on the kingdom she knew, the kingdom she was sure would never change. She had it all mapped out. An inefficient guild and overly conservative council clinging to their traditions above all else. Only one thing stood out: a young leader, a woman… with lots of ties to someone she had once known…

Dainty strings of reputation, which had once been attached to a powerful sorcerer, a king, were now used to puppeteer the pretty little thing.

So really it didn't change anything… She had no real influence…

The only thing left was putting a face to all those figures in her picture.

Since manipulating Adora into returning would take time and preparation, she could gather as much intel as needed.

First, her spies stealthily scouted the buildings, the gardens, the beach, while Shadow Weaver kept her eyes locked on Adora.

Through the basin she could see it all very clearly.

Adora had been received by none other than… a very… cheerful woman?

Nothing about her manner was queen-like, yet the halo gently shined around her head. *So that's Micah's sister, the Head Sorceress*, she thought. She had at least expected some grace but *even that* was too much to ask, it seemed.

How exactly could the Sorcerers' Guild have fallen so *low*!?

Shadow Weaver didn't know if she should be disappointed by Mystacor as one of its former people, or relieved as one of its biggest enemies.

She chose relief. After all she is not Light Spinner…

Not anymore, fortunately.

After having to bear listening to the overbearing woman's rambling about how much she wanted to feed her niece, give them a tour, and show them that pitiful ceremony to reinforce their shield, the dark sorceress finally found the perfect moment to set her plan in motion.

Adora's attention diverted just enough from her noisy companions, and there she saw it: one of the shadow spies.

The girl ran into the corridor, the Hall of Sorcerers… quite the convenient place.

Her statue, or rather, that of her old self, was there. Wouldn't it be just the perfect irony?

Once Adora saw it…

But of course, the Head Sorceress and the other two arrived soon enough, so she'd have to wait just a tiny bit. Normally, it wouldn't be a problem, but hearing the name of Micah was far from pleasant, and suddenly the wait felt eternal.

The Head Sorceress droned on about her brother.

She chuckled bitterly, it was fascinating and jarring. How could someone of his skill and proficiency ever be related to… that woman?

The sorceress went on to tell Adora an overdramatic story about "Light Spinner"…

Shadow Weaver was so annoyed she almost missed it when Adora remained, studying her statue, while the rest walked away.

It was time for the second step in her plan.

She could see Adora noticed the familiarity, so no more than casting a shadow would suffice…

Oh, that defensive standing when that Princess returned to her!

That was the soldier she trained.

The paranoid child she *raised*.

Always ready to strike.

—*You okay?*— the boy in the mirage, Bow, asked her.

—*It's worse than we thought*— the Princess added.

Her ward's expression at her "friends" actually gave Shadow Weaver an idea.

The following step should be to *isolate Adora*.

She'd only have to start the process, and her ward alone would do the rest.

—It's time for something more— she let out, observing the three kids walk way.

Raising both hands, she summoned more power, enough to conjure herself into a shadow spy as if she were back in the island herself…

From her hiding spot, Shadow Weaver could see the three kids resting on Mystacor's beach.

Adora, restless as ever, couldn't simply fall asleep…

Bidding her time, the dark sorceress patiently held out for the perfect moment.

Shock and fear wasn't enough. She had to be… more subtle. Give her a false sense of security and destroy it as soon as she eased into it.

So when the three fell asleep in one of the Steam Grotto's pools, Shadow Weaver lurked.

She knew Adora would wake up before the other two, and when she did…

Her illusions were ready.

A dark mist surrounded the pool, and through her summoned form Shadow Weaver called her name.

As soon as Adora leaped out of the pool, screaming, the mist followed her, threateningly enough to make the girl go straight for her sword.

And then…

She was gone.

Adora herself asked to be left alone.

How unwise… and how *perfect*.

As soon as her friends were out of sight, Shadow Weaver mimicked the voice of the Princess, inciting self-doubt and only further igniting her paranoia.

Adora had now walked back into the Hall of Sorcerers, and once again studied the statue of Light Spinner.

Perhaps the silly story that Head Sorceress told her got into Adora's head?

In any case, Shadow Weaver knew exactly what she had to do to isolate her for good, to force Adora back to her side.

With a bit of a push, the mimicry of Catra's voice, of Hordak's voice, and a simple illusion…

She-Ra broke.

And Adora, her Adora was restored.

It would have been much better if she had caused the shield protecting Mystacor to fall, but… she didn't need that. Shadow Weaver could handle that herself.

All she required was what came next, as a consequence of the lunar crystals destruction.

Being honest with herself, the dark sorceress didn't expect that foolish woman to be… so useful to her.

As soon as the Head Sorceress saw the smashed crystals, she went almost insane.

There was a hint of something in her eyes, in her voice, that almost didn't align with her emotions.

Shadow Weaver took it as a weakness, no bite to back up all that barking.

What mattered was that Adora felt such rejection, that even when her friends tried to reassure her, Shadow Weaver could see she was on the brink of giving up.

After letting Adora rest for a bit, just enough to avoid raising suspicions, the dark sorceress conjured an illusion of the Princess of Bright Moon, to tell Adora just how disappointed she was, and how bad she was at being friends… and that she should *leave*.

That would be enough.

With Adora on her way out of Mystacor, Shadow Weaver could now focus on her revenge.

The ceremony to reinforce the invisibility spell around the island would soon begin. If she took over the power of the eclipse, then she could easily corrupt the Lunarium, interrupting the ceremony, and most importantly, leaving Mystacor defenseless.

It'd be hers for the taking, Adora would return to her side under the belief that not even her "friends" want her around…

Shadow Weaver would succeed.

As the ceremony began, the dark sorceress waited patiently for the right moment. The most… vulnerable moment.

She let the Head Sorceress begin, prepare, move the lenses as soon as the eclipse began, and…

She disturbed it at the most critical instance, aiming to keep the Lunarium under her control until the eclipse finished; then Mystacor would lose its only protection.

And yet, after the initial shock of her interference, Shadow Weaver found herself being… resisted. The Head Sorceress was fighting her. Shielding the lenses, trying to push her dark magic away.

Both the speed and power of the initial reaction startled her but she knew it wouldn't last long: no sorceress has ever been a match for a runestone.

Shadow Weaver only needed to leech a bit more power from the Black Garnet…

Maybe more than a bit.

The resisting magic went as quickly as it came… with a jolt that made it feel like it had been withdrawn rather than crushed down by its opposing force.

Shadow Weaver took the opportunity to knock everyone down.

The woman fell to the floor along with her subordinates, the side of her face hitting the cold tile.

It was… not the initial idea, but something told her she'd need the extra layer of reassurance that her plan wouldn't be interrupted.

Besides, by now Adora had figured out the truth. She had discovered the shadow spy and now headed for the Lunarium.

Waiting for her to barge in, she scanned the floor, looking at the now still faces of the guild, eyes circling back to the Head Sorceress.

She faced her, albeit unconscious. Her nose seemed turned upwards, pointing sharply to the ceiling.

Yet before the dark sorceress got to laugh at that, Adora's hurried steps called her attention.

It was time.

Despite her best efforts, Shadow Weaver failed.

Adora managed to expel her.

She was stronger than previously believed; she was as strong as… runestone princesses…

The dark sorceress woke up on the ground.

She could hardly believe how pathetic she had been… defeated by a teen…

Oh, and those sorcerers from the guild probably felt so smug right now.

One day she'd teach them a lesson…

But that day wasn't today, it seemed.

Meanwhile, back in Mystacor, Head Sorceress Castaspella was just biding farewell to her niece and friends.

Her cheery expression evened out into neutrality as she watched them walk away. Her gaze lingered on Adora.

Not moving her eyes off the girl she turned her head to a cloaked man nearby and in a hushed voice gave an order to keep everyone out. Soon after every guild member was quietly pulled away from their occupations to discreetly begin reinforcing every defense spell protecting Mystacor.

From outside, the Council said nothing and the people saw nothing.

From how quick she reacted yet how calm she stayed it was difficult to understand how much this attack had truly threatened her.

Was she scared? With how sudden Shadow Weaver's intrusion and attack had been this reaction would only be natural…

Was she reassured? The power their new ally had displayed was certainly promising…

It did not seem to matter as when she passed through the halls no one looked past her quickly painted on bubbly look and lively smile.

End Notes

:D

Intrigued!? I sure hope so
There's one more one-shot to come for each season, and as I mentioned before, even some art! I can't wait for you all to see the amazing stuff Es has been cooking XD

So! See you next week in part two of this series!! :D
I promise it will only get more *interesting* >v<

Thank you all for reading!!
~Xenakis

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!